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able is farmed. China produces more than 65% of the world's caviar, with more than 500,000 sturgeon swimming in its farms—far outnumbering the wild population in the Caspian Sea. Because of this industrial-scale production, they've managed to bring down prices.

How is caviar made? I attended a caviar appreciation class and tasting last year in Dubai, organised by leading French caviar manufacturer Kaviari, and was surprised to learn that just determining which sturgeon are female (the only ones capable of producing roe) can take up to three years. Once the females are identified, it can take anywhere from 5-15 years for them to reach maturity. The extraction of the caviar from the sturgeon is done by hand by trained experts, after which the roe undergoes meticulous washing, salting, and ageing—a process that can take months to perfect. By the time a tin of caviar is ready for sale, it has been through a complex and careful process.

There are over 27 recognised species of sturgeon found across the world. These include the better-known species: Sevruga, Oscietra, and Beluga. Each species offers caviar with its own unique flavour profile, texture, size, and colour. Connoisseurs use these factors to

rank them from good to extraordinary, creating what can only be described as a caste system for sturgeon roe. Many caviar farms also cross-breed sturgeon to produce roe with entirely new characteristics. These hybrids are designed to enhance flavour and texture. Some of these hybrid varieties, such as Daurenki, Bester, and Kaluga, are now highly coveted. And firms, like Kaviari, have proprietary varieties, such as the Michelin-star restaurant favourite Kristal.

But how to tell good caviar from bad? There are no hard and fast rules, and a lot depends on personal preferences. Generally, larger eggs are considered more desirable, but it's about more than just size. Good caviar should hold its integrity in the